

Three Roads: Choose Your Strategy with AI

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My four constraints

- Free tools only.
- Real skill level: beginner in web development. I've already coded with strong AI support (the Brigadeira Stock project, in C#/ASP.NET), but I don't know code by heart.
- What the portfolio needs to do: 4 static pages — Home, Proof/Case Study, About, Contact — with structured text case studies, real screenshots, a before/after table, and a personal photo.
- How the work should be displayed: text + images/screenshots. No live demo, no notebook, no code repository as a centerpiece.
- Nothing needs to be dynamic at launch — Contact uses an email/LinkedIn link, not a form.

Three options (simplest to most powerful)

Option 1 — No-code (e.g. Carrd)

How to build	Visual drag-and-drop editor with ready-made templates.
Free hosting	Built-in publishing within the tool itself.
Needs a backend?	No.
Real drawback	Limited design control on the free tier — the exact font pairing from my identity kit (Tinos serif for the name only + Arimo everywhere else) may not be configurable with precision; the tool tends to push toward generic templates.

Option 2 — Simple HTML/CSS with AI support, hosted on Netlify

How to build	Write real HTML and CSS together with AI, file by file, understanding what each part does.
Free hosting	Netlify (drag and drop the folder at app.netlify.com/drop), free forever.
Needs a backend?	No.
Real drawback	I need to ask AI for help whenever I want to change something — no visual editor. Small but real learning curve.

Option 3 — Full framework (e.g. Next.js/React, hosted on Vercel)

How to build	A complete development environment, with components, a build step, and configuration.
Free hosting	Vercel, free tier.

Needs a backend?	Not right now, but the structure is ready to add one later.
Real drawback	Total overkill for 4 static pages. Much of the timeline would go into fixing build errors and configuration instead of finishing the case studies. Steep learning curve for someone still learning to code.

Stress test (on the most promising option: HTML/CSS + Netlify)

What breaks if I pick the simplest one (no-code)? I lose fine control over my identity kit's typography — the Tinos/Arimo pairing might not come out exactly as planned.

What do I keep if I pick the most powerful one (framework)? Nothing I actually need right now — I have no dynamic content, and no plan to add a backend soon.

Can I finish in two weeks? Yes, with simple HTML/CSS and step-by-step AI support. With the framework, it's risky — the time could all go into configuration.

Does it show my work the way it needs to be shown? Yes — it gives full control to reproduce exactly the case studies, screenshots, and visual identity I already defined.

Decision

I chose: Simple HTML and CSS, written with AI support, hosted on Netlify.

I didn't choose the no-code option because my identity kit already has specific typography and color decisions I want to reproduce precisely — I don't want to find out the free template doesn't allow that after I've already built the site.

I didn't choose the framework because my portfolio doesn't need anything dynamic right now, and the extra complexity would only increase the risk of not finishing in time. If I ever need more (a real contact form, for example), I can migrate later — I don't need to decide that today.

Can I maintain this? Yes — these are simple HTML/CSS files, and I'll actually understand how each part works because I built it with AI step by step, instead of just clicking around a visual editor.

Does this show my work well? Yes — it gives full control over how the case studies, screenshots, and visual identity appear, without the limitations of a ready-made template.

Do I need a backend now? No, not yet. The portfolio is static content only — text, images, and links. If I ever want a functional contact form, I'll decide that when I get there.